

THE VOICE THAT HELPED THEM FIND THEIRS

He arrived to a squad unsure of itself. **Joakim Alexandersson** has helped reshape it by steadying minds before systems.

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When Joakim Alexandersson first met the Indian women's Under-17 and U-20 teams at the start of the year, he immediately noticed how shy they were – talented, but overly cautious. As a coach beginning a new job, one of Joakim's priorities was to make sure the players did not feel intimidated by anything, least of all by him.

"I've worked a lot to make sure they understand they don't have to be afraid of me," says Joakim. "I'm just a human being, even if I don't have any hair or speak their language."

Ten months and two long-awaited Asian Cup qualifications later, Joakim's assessment of the group carried a very different tone. "It seems like nothing can stop them now."

A very good mindset

Joakim believes football is as much a mental game as it is a physical one. He does not compromise on discipline and expects a "fighting spirit" from every player.

"The hard work has to be there. I don't want to see casual players on the pitch," Joakim asserts.

"Players all around the world make mistakes, that's fine. It's more about behaviour. If you have a very good mindset to win the ball back after mistakes, if you can forget mistakes quickly, that's what I value," the

49-year-old adds.

This restlessness and ambition were evident throughout both teams' qualifying campaigns, particularly in the U-17 side. While the U-20 team secured its place with two wins, a draw, and no goals conceded, the younger group had a tougher path. After defeating the host Kyrgyzstan 2-1, India went into a decisive match against Uzbekistan, needing only a draw to qualify.

Uzbekistan, which has risen sharply in recent years, qualifying for the FIFA World Cup 2026 and winning the men's AFC U-17 Asian Cup in April, posed a formidable challenge.

On the day, India went a goal down before turning the tide, sparked by Joakim's early substitutions. After Uzbekistan scored in the 38th minute, Joakim reacted quickly and brought on Thandamoni Baskey with five minutes left in the first half. The midfielder scored the equaliser and later set up Anushka Kumari's winner.

Joakim says such decisions come from understanding exactly what he wants from each position.

"You see a problem on the pitch, you make the change then and there. That's why I decided to do some early substitutions in this latest game, because I needed to see some changes. We were struggling a lot, especially in how we created chances," Joakim explained.

"If I can't see these kinds of actions, then it's very simple: we have to make some changes," he adds.

Balancing dual roles

For Joakim, managing two different age groups has not been as demanding as it might seem. The

